PARTNER ONE-PAGER

When your client hired a COO and is still the COO

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What I do

A founder hired a COO or a Head of Ops so things would stop going through them. It all still goes through them. I run **the Handoff**: 30 days to get decisions off the founder's desk and onto the person they hired. We count what reaches the founder before, change what's causing it and count again at day 30. If the count hasn't dropped by 30%, the second month is on me.

If you know a founder like this, tell me who. One paragraph is enough, and I'll reply within one business day.

I don't do the implementation, and I don't take over your client. If you're already working with them, your work keeps going.

What it does for your work

If you're a fractional COO or CFO. The fix is clear, and the founder still won't let go of the decisions it depends on. Your engagement stalls and the renewal gets shaky. Bring me in on that client. I find out why the decisions keep coming back, and if the founder agrees, you're in the room when we change who decides what. Tell me which client.

If you place COOs, Heads of Ops or GMs. The placement went fine. Three months in, the founder still hasn't let the new hire own anything, and a failed placement comes back to you. Offer your client a free **Handoff Kickoff** as part of your placement: 45 minutes with the founder and the new hire together, in the first weeks. They sort last week's decisions into "the founder's", "the new hire's" and "unclear", and they leave with a one-week log running. Tell me who and I'll set it up with both of them. If it's later heading toward a replacement search, introduce me before that search starts. Sometimes it is the wrong hire. Often it's the right person in a setup where they can't really own anything.

If you run a room (a fund, a program, a community). I run a free 60-minute live clinic for your founders on "Why does everything still depend on the founder?" Two of them bring a real decision and I work it live. Nobody gets pitched. If you'd like one, tell me about your room.

When to think of me

A founder or CEO hired a COO, a Head of Ops, a GM or a senior lead **so the company would depend less on them**, and it still depends on them.

- Decisions the new leader was hired to own still land on the founder's desk.
- The team waits for the founder's yes on things that aren't the founder's call anymore.
- The founder takes a week off and things slow down.
- The founder is starting to wonder whether they hired the wrong person.

That last one is the best moment to introduce me: **before anyone gets fired.**

This also applies before the hire. If a founder is betting that "once the Head of Ops is in, this stops," that's worth a look before the bet is placed.

The phrases to listen for

Real things founders have said:

- "Every important decision comes back to me."
- "We need to go from founder to system."
- "I thought doing more would fix it. It just made things worse."
- "I hired a COO and I'm still the COO."
- "I'm paying someone senior and I still answer every question."

They don't need to say it exactly. The pattern is: **a reasonable fix already happened or is about to (usually a hire), and the decisions still find their way back to the founder.**

Who it's for, and who it isn't

For founder-led companies with customers and a team, usually 10 to 150 people, where the founder can actually change how decisions get made once the cause is clear. Funding stage doesn't matter much. If you're not sure it fits, tell me who anyway and I'll say.

Pass when the business is still an idea, nobody can name what it's costing or the founder wants someone else to do the implementation for them.

How to introduce me

Tell me who. One paragraph is enough: who the founder is, what the company does, roughly how many people and what keeps landing back on their desk. You don't need to sell me on them. I'll reply within one business day.

If you'd rather they get in touch themselves, here's a line you can send them:

> "You hired good people and decisions still come back to you. My friend Trung works out why, and whether the fix is the person or the setup: linkedin.com/in/ctn1991. DM him 'diagnostic' to start."

Or forward the essay: I hired someone. Why is the problem still on my desk?.

What happens after you introduce someone

- **You hear back.** Within two days of the first session you get a short note from me: whether it went ahead, and whatever the founder is OK with me sharing that matters for your work. If there's a 30-day follow-through, you hear how it ended.
- **Your relationship is safe.** If it's not the right fit or the right time, I say so directly.
- **What the founder tells me stays with the founder** unless they say otherwise.

What you get back

Tell me who *your* ideal client is and what to listen for. When I hear it, I send them your way. There are no fees in either direction.

Live version: iamtrung.com/d/partner-one-pager